



Lecture Notes

Institute Name:	Silver Oak College of Computer Application		
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Course Code:	MDC5011C	Course Name:	Ethical and Legal Frameworks for Digital Systems
Unit No.:	1	Unit Name:	Introduction to Ethics and Digital Citizenship

1. Introduction to Ethics and Morality

Meaning of Ethics

Ethics refers to a set of principles and standards that help individuals determine what is **right, wrong, fair, responsible, and acceptable** in a particular situation.

In the digital world, ethics guides how people should use computers, mobile devices, the Internet, social media, artificial intelligence, data, and digital services.

Example:

Downloading someone else's private photographs and sharing them without permission may be technically possible, but it is ethically wrong because it violates privacy and consent.

Meaning of Morality

Morality refers to an individual's or society's beliefs about what is right and wrong.

Ethics and morality are closely related but have a slight difference:

- **Morality** generally represents personal or social beliefs about right and wrong.
- **Ethics** provides principles or frameworks for evaluating and making decisions about right and wrong.

Ethics vs. Morality

Ethics	Morality
Systematic principles for deciding right and wrong	Beliefs about right and wrong
Often associated with professions and organizations	Often influenced by family, culture, religion, and society

Used for professional decision-making	Used in personal and social behavior
Example: IT professional maintaining client confidentiality	Example: Believing that stealing is wrong

Importance of Ethics

Ethics helps individuals:

1. Make responsible decisions.
2. Respect the rights of others.
3. Protect privacy and confidentiality.
4. Maintain honesty and transparency.
5. Avoid misuse of technology.
6. Build trust.
7. Understand the consequences of digital actions.

2. Importance of Ethics in Digital Society

A **digital society** is a society in which digital technologies play an important role in communication, education, business, government, healthcare, entertainment, and everyday activities.

People continuously generate and exchange digital information through:

- Social media
- Online banking
- E-commerce
- Cloud computing
- Mobile applications
- Artificial intelligence
- IoT devices
- Educational platforms
- Digital government services

Because digital technology can affect millions of people quickly, ethical behavior becomes extremely important.

Major Ethical Principles in Digital Society

1. Privacy

Individuals should have control over their personal information.



Example: An application should not collect unnecessary personal information without informing users.

2. Security

Digital systems should protect information against unauthorized access, modification, and destruction.

3. Transparency

Organizations should clearly explain how they collect, process, and use user information.

4. Accountability

Individuals and organizations should accept responsibility for the consequences of their digital activities.

5. Fairness

Technology should not unfairly discriminate against individuals or groups.

6. Respect

Users should communicate and behave respectfully in digital environments.

7. Consent

Personal data, photographs, videos, and other digital content should not be used without appropriate permission.

Why Digital Ethics Is Important

Digital actions can have:

- **Individual impact** – privacy loss, reputation damage, financial loss.
- **Organizational impact** – loss of customer trust and business reputation.
- **Social impact** – misinformation, cyberbullying, discrimination.
- **Legal impact** – penalties and legal proceedings.
- **Global impact** – digital platforms can affect users across countries.

3. Professional Ethics in Information Technology

Professional ethics in IT refers to the principles and responsibilities that IT professionals should follow while designing, developing, managing, and using technology.



IT professionals often have access to sensitive information and powerful technological systems. Therefore, ethical responsibility is essential.

Important Principles

1. Confidentiality

An IT professional must protect confidential information.

Example: A database administrator should not disclose a customer's personal information to unauthorized people.

2. Integrity

Information should remain accurate and should not be intentionally manipulated.

3. Professional Competence

IT professionals should maintain appropriate technical knowledge and continuously improve their skills.

4. Honesty

Professionals should provide truthful information about:

- System capabilities
- Security risks
- Project progress
- Technical limitations
- Costs and resources

5. Avoidance of Conflict of Interest

An IT professional should avoid situations where personal interests influence professional decisions.

6. Respect for Intellectual Property

Professionals should respect:

- Copyright
- Patents
- Software licenses
- Trademarks
- Proprietary information

7. Responsible Technology Development

Developers should consider possible social and ethical consequences of the systems they create.

Example: An AI-based recruitment system should be evaluated for discriminatory bias before deployment.

4. Responsible Use of Computers and Internet

Responsible use means using computers, networks, and Internet services in a **legal, ethical, secure, and respectful manner**.

Responsible Computer Usage

Users should:

- Use licensed or legally available software.
- Protect passwords and authentication credentials.
- Keep software updated.
- Use antivirus and security controls.
- Respect other users' files and accounts.
- Avoid unauthorized system access.
- Maintain backups of important data.
- Avoid downloading suspicious files.
- Report security incidents.

Responsible Internet Usage

Users should:

- Verify information before sharing it.
- Respect copyright.
- Avoid spreading misinformation.
- Protect personal information.
- Use strong passwords.
- Enable multi-factor authentication where available.
- Avoid suspicious links.
- Respect others during online communication.

Irresponsible Digital Behavior

Examples include:

- Hacking another person's account.

- Password sharing.
- Software piracy.
- Identity theft.
- Cyberbullying.
- Spreading fake news.
- Unauthorized access to databases.
- Sharing private photographs without consent.
- Plagiarism.
- Creating fake online identities to deceive others.

5. Digital Citizenship and Online Behavior

Meaning of Digital Citizenship

Digital citizenship refers to the responsible, safe, ethical, and effective participation of individuals in the digital world.

A good digital citizen understands both **digital rights and digital responsibilities**.

Characteristics of a Good Digital Citizen

A responsible digital citizen:

1. Respects others online.
2. Protects personal information.
3. Uses technology responsibly.
4. Follows laws and regulations.
5. Verifies information before sharing.
6. Respects intellectual property.
7. Maintains appropriate online behavior.
8. Reports harmful or illegal activities.
9. Understands cybersecurity risks.
10. Thinks about the long-term consequences of online actions.

Digital Rights

Examples include:

- Right to privacy
- Right to access information
- Right to express opinions within legal boundaries
- Right to security
- Right to protection from online abuse

Digital Responsibilities

Users are responsible for:

- Protecting their accounts.
- Respecting others' privacy.
- Avoiding harmful content.
- Following applicable laws.
- Using digital resources responsibly.
- Reporting abuse and security incidents.

6. Digital Footprint and Online Reputation

Digital Footprint

A **digital footprint** is the trail of information that an individual leaves behind through digital activities.

Examples include:

- Social media posts
- Comments
- Likes and shares
- Search activities
- Online purchases
- Uploaded photographs
- Emails
- Website registrations
- Online reviews

Types of Digital Footprints

1. Active Digital Footprint

Information that a person intentionally shares.

Examples:

- Posting a photograph.
- Writing a social media comment.
- Completing an online form.

2. Passive Digital Footprint



Information collected through digital activities, sometimes without direct user action.

Examples:

- Website cookies
- IP addresses
- Browsing information
- Device information
- Location data

Online Reputation

Online reputation refers to how an individual, organization, or brand is perceived based on information available online.

A negative digital footprint can affect:

- Employment opportunities
- Academic opportunities
- Professional relationships
- Personal relationships
- Business reputation

Managing Digital Footprints

Users should:

- Think before posting.
- Review privacy settings.
- Avoid sharing unnecessary personal information.
- Remove inappropriate content where possible.
- Monitor online profiles.
- Use professional communication.
- Verify information before publishing.

Important Concept

Think before you post because digital content may be difficult to completely remove once it is shared.

7. Cyberbullying, Online Harassment, and Digital Responsibility

Cyberbullying

Cyberbullying is the use of digital technologies to repeatedly intimidate, threaten, humiliate, or harm another person.

It can occur through:

- Social media
- Messaging applications
- Online games
- Email
- Discussion forums
- Video-sharing platforms

Examples

- Sending threatening messages.
- Creating fake accounts to insult someone.
- Sharing embarrassing photographs.
- Spreading rumors online.
- Repeatedly posting abusive comments.

Online Harassment

Online harassment involves unwanted, offensive, threatening, or abusive digital behavior directed toward an individual or group.

Cyberbullying and harassment can cause:

- Emotional distress
- Loss of confidence
- Social isolation
- Academic or professional difficulties
- Damage to reputation

How to Respond

A victim should:

1. Avoid engaging in unnecessary arguments.
2. Save evidence such as screenshots.
3. Block the offender where appropriate.
4. Report abusive content to the platform.
5. Inform a trusted authority or institution.
6. Seek appropriate support.



Digital Responsibility

Every user has a responsibility to avoid causing harm to others through digital technologies.

Before posting or sending content, ask:

Is it true? Is it respectful? Is it necessary? Could it harm someone?

8. Ethical Issues in Social Media Usage

Social media provides powerful communication capabilities, but it also creates significant ethical challenges.

1. Privacy

Users may unintentionally expose personal information.

Example: Posting someone's photograph without permission.

2. Misinformation and Fake News

False or misleading information can spread rapidly through social media.

Users should verify information before sharing it.

3. Cyberbullying

Social platforms can be used to harass or intimidate individuals.

4. Identity and Impersonation

Creating fake profiles to impersonate another person can cause reputational and financial harm.

5. Copyright Infringement

Copying and distributing another person's content without appropriate permission may violate intellectual property rights.

6. Manipulation and Algorithms

Social media platforms use recommendation algorithms to determine what users see. Ethical concerns can arise when algorithms:

- Promote harmful content.
- Create filter bubbles.
- Amplify misinformation.



- Exploit user attention.
- Produce unfair recommendations.

7. Targeted Advertising

Platforms may use user behavior and personal information for targeted advertising. This creates concerns about:

- Privacy
- Consent
- Transparency
- User profiling

8. Deepfakes and Synthetic Media

AI-generated images, videos, and audio can be used to create misleading or deceptive content.

Ethical Social Media Practices

Users should:

- Verify information.
- Respect privacy.
- Obtain consent before sharing personal content.
- Avoid abusive language.
- Credit original creators.
- Report harmful content.
- Think about long-term consequences.

9. Ethical Decision-Making in Everyday Digital Activities

Ethical decision-making means systematically evaluating a situation before choosing a digital action.

Five-Step Ethical Decision-Making Process

Step 1: Identify the Situation

Understand what happened and identify the ethical issue.

Example: You receive a confidential document belonging to another person.

Step 2: Identify the Stakeholders



Determine who may be affected.

Possible stakeholders:

- You
- Owner of the information
- Organization
- Customers
- Other users

Step 3: Identify Possible Actions

Consider different choices.

For example:

- Read the document.
- Share it with others.
- Delete it.
- Inform the owner.

Step 4: Evaluate the Consequences

Consider:

- Is the action legal?
- Is it fair?
- Does it violate privacy?
- Could it cause harm?
- Does it respect consent?
- Does it follow professional responsibilities?

Step 5: Select and Review the Decision

Choose the most ethical option and consider the consequences of the decision.

10. Everyday Digital Ethics Examples

Example 1: Sharing a Photograph

Situation: You have a photograph of your friend and want to upload it publicly.

Ethical consideration: Ask for permission before publishing it.

Principle: Privacy and consent.



Example 2: Using Someone's Assignment

Situation: A classmate sends you their assignment and you submit it as your own.

Ethical issue: Plagiarism.

Principle: Academic integrity and intellectual property.

Example 3: Forwarding Unverified News

Situation: You receive a message claiming that an important public event has occurred.

Ethical action: Verify the information before forwarding it.

Principle: Information responsibility.

Example 4: Using Another Person's Account

Situation: You know your friend's password and use the account without permission.

Ethical issue: Unauthorized access and privacy violation.

Ethical action: Do not access the account without explicit authorization.

Example 5: AI-Generated Content

Situation: A student uses AI to generate an assignment and submits it entirely as their own work when course rules prohibit this.

Ethical issues:

- Academic integrity
- Lack of transparency
- Misrepresentation of work

Ethical action: Follow institutional AI-use policies and disclose AI assistance where required.